The Sovereignty Of God

HOW GOD SAVES TOTALLY DEPRAVED SINNERS

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Part 1

God's Evaluation of Man

THE GENESIS RECORD

THE only one who is able to give us a true evaluation of man is God, the One who created him.

Man, as he was originally created, was made in the image and likeness of God (Gen. 1:26-27).

Man, as he was created, is evaluated as being good (Gen. 1:31).

Man, as he was formed by God, was a free moral agent; i.e., he had the ability to choose between what God said was right and wrong. This means that he was not confirmed in his good state (Gen. 2:6-7).

Man, as a free moral agent, while he was still in his state of goodness, deliberately chose to follow the Word of God's adversary rather than the Word of God (Gen. 3:1-6).

As a result of man's choice, even before he was tainted by sin, he fell under God's judgment of death (Gen. 2:17; 3:2-3). We understand this to mean both spiritual and physical death -- a total cutoff from Divine life.

In contrast to and beyond the animals which God made, we read, "God formed man of the dust of the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and man became a living soul" (Gen. 2:7). It appears to me that this special impartation of life to man was withdrawn when he disobeyed God and died. To die is to be dead, incapable of moving after spiritual death, which set in immediately, and after physical death, which followed in due time.

THE NEW TESTAMENT RECORD

ACCORDING to Romans chapter 1, men have suppressed the truth in unrighteousness (v. 18). Even though they knew God through natural revelation, they refused to glorify Him as God, and "were madevain in their reasonings and theirsenseless heart was darkened, they worshiped idols, and as a result, God gave "them up to uncleanness, in the lusts of their hearts, to dishonor their bodies among themselves" (vv. 19-24).

These depraved men "exchanged the truth of God for the lie, the women practiced lesbianism, the men practiced sodomy; having refused knowledge of God, He gave them

over to a depraved mind. They were filled with unrighteousness, wickedness, deceit, arrogance, void of understanding and unmerciful" (vv. 25-32).

In Romans 3:9, Paul says "we have previously charged that both Jews and Greeks are all under sin." Having said this he now confirms it by citing pertinent passages from the Old Testament. According to these citations no one is righteous, none understands or seeks after God. There is none who does good. Their throat is an open tomb, they deceive and the poison of asps is under their lips. Their mouth is full of cursing and bitterness. Their feet are swift to shed blood, ruin and misery follow them, they are unacquainted with peace and have ηο fear of God (Rom. 3:1-18).

According to Romans 3:23, "all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God." As we cogitate on the first three chapters in Romans, our conclusion is -- man is utterly depraved!

"If we hold that Adam's sin cut him off from God, completely broke his relationship with God then it follows that his progeny are in the same plight."

Romans 5:12 explicitly states that sin came into the world through Adam, his penalty was death, and since all men are inflicted with death, this is evidence that all have sinned. The same death penalty, the result of sin, inextricably unites all believers with Adam's sin. Verses 16-19 reaffirm the sin and death link between Adam and his progeny, for we read, "the judgment was out of one unto condemnation... by the trespasses of one, death reigned through the one... through one trespass condemnation came unto all men... through the disobedience of one man many were made sinners."

If we hold that Adam's sin cut him off from God, completely broke his relationship with God, then it follows that his progeny are in the same plight. The fact that Cain expressed his anger against God (Gen. 4:5) and killed his brother indicates that he had inherited his father's rebellious nature and disposition. Instead of worshiping God he desired to be as God (Gen. 3:5,22).

This leads us to the conclusion that like Cain, our older brother, we have the same deranged human nature inherited from Adam. All natural men in the flesh have an antipathy toward God. They consciously and unconsciously are motivated to dethrone God and to enthrone self. They are not all murderers, but subtly sublimate the same inclinations, particularly, when they don't get their way or their pride is hurt.

In Romans 7:14, Paul says, "I am carnal, having been sold under sin." In verse 18, he says, "for I know that it does not dwell in me, that is in my flesh, good." In verse 24, Paul cries out, "A wretched man I am; who will deliver me out of the body of this death?" Paul recognized that the Adamic flesh-mind could not deliver him out of his death body -

- he needed help beyond himself. No one since Adam has had a real relationship with God, apart from the love and mercy of God (Eph. 2:4).

One of the finest descriptions we have of the natural man in the New Testament is found in Ephesians 2:1-3. The Apostle Paul says via the Spirit; "And you being dead in your trespasses and sins, in which you once walked according to the age of this world, according to the ruler of the authority of the air, the spirit now working in the sons of disobedience; among whom we also once lived in the lusts of our flesh, doing the will of the flesh and of the thoughts, and we were by nature children of wrath even as also the rest."

According to these verses the natural man is dead in sin. His lifestyle is according to Satan's blueprint for this age. His life is dominated by the ruler of the authority of the air, namely, Satan. He lives in the lusts of the flesh and does the will of the mind of the flesh. In his nature he is a child of wrath. This obviously teachers that both Gentiles and Jews, in their very nature, are totally depraved sinners.

In view of God's evaluation of man, he is a totally depraved sinner separated from God, dead spiritually and on death row physically, and he himself within himself is unable to extricate himself apart from outside help.

Part 2

How God Saves Totally Depraved Sinners

THIS subject may also be entitled HOW GOD BRINGS SPIRITUALLY DEAD SINNERS INTO A LIVING RELATIONSHIP WITH HIMSELF. An appropriate theological title would be GOD'S SOVEREIGNTY IN SOTERIOLOGY.

What we will be saying on this subject will make sense *only* to those who are *totally subordinate* to what God says about THE FALL OF ADAM and its CONFIRMATION BY HIS PROGENY (Gen. 3:4,19; 4:8,11-12,16; Rom. 3:9-18,23; 7:14; Eph. 3:1-3; Titus 3:3-4). If our minds are infiltrated and permeated with humanistic evaluations of man, consciously or subconsciously, then one will be led to think that dead sinners, in themselves, are capable of initiating a relationship with God.

If this secular, humanistic appraisal of man is true, then may I ask, Why does God emphasize in His Word that He is THE INITIATOR of the salvation relationship? (Acts 13:48; 16:14; Rom. 8:28-30; 9:10-18, 23-24; 11:6-7; 1 Cor.1:30; Eph. 1:3-6; 11-12; Col. 3:12; 1 Thess. 1:4; 2 Tim 2:10; Titus 1:1; 1 Peter 1:1, 9; 2 Peter 1:10).

GOD'S LOVE AND MERCY

In view of the overwhelming evidence, which cannot be denied, it is obvious that *God has a sovereign purpose* to restore men back into fellowship with Himself (Col. 3:9-10). We raise the question, what has motivated God to reinstate men into this living relationship with Himself? The clear answer, which has pealed out for many millenniums, even from before the creation of the world, is LOVE.

Ephesians 1:4-5, declares that God, motivated by LOVE, predestined us to be holy and blameless sons. This involved His *individually choosing us*, before the creation of the world, to be identified with Christ, hence, holy and blameless in Him (cf. 1 Thess. 1:4; 2 Thess. 2:13).

According to Ephesians 2:1-3, we have a picture of the *utter depravity* of the entire human race; all are deranged sinners in their nature, *spiritually dead*, and not interested in nor capable of making the slightest movement toward God. In the midst of this *hopeless dilemma*, from man's viewpoint, God's LOVE motivated Him to be *rich in mercy* toward us while we were yet sinners (cf. Eph. 2:4). The result: He made us spiritually alive together with Christ, i.e., saved us by His grace.

According to Titus 3:4-5, God's kindness, *affection* and *LOVE* for mankind (φιλανθρωκια) has motivated Him to save sinners according to His mercy. This and the

foregoing verse (Eph. 2:4) imply that *God's love precedes His mercy* in the sovereign restitution of sinners to Himself.

The sovereignty of God in soteriology is not only *a doctrine of love* but also of MERCY (ελεος), *clemency* and *compassion*. In Romans 9:14-18, God says that He will have mercy on whom He wills to have mercy. The sinner's salvation is *not determined* by his personal "willing" (θελοντος) or "running" (τρεχοντος), i.e., by his own volition or by what he does, but *by the mercy God gives to him*. Summarizing these verses, God gives mercy to whom He wills, and He leaves the rest in their Adamic hardness.

According to Romans 9:23-24, those to whom God has extended mercy are referred to as *vessels of mercy*, which God pre-prepared beforehand unto glory. These vessels of mercy are *individually called* out of both the Jews and Gentiles (cf. Rom. 11:30-32).

According to First Peter 1:1-3, the Apostle Peter is writing to elect Jews who have been saved according to the foreknowledge of God. Also, *because of God's great mercy to them*, they had been born again unto a living hope, unto an incorruptible inheritance, which has been reserved in heaven for them. The order is: the elect are the recipients of God's love, which elicits God's mercy upon them, which results in their salvation (cf. Titus 3:5).

> *"The sovereignty of God in soteriology is not only a doctrine of love but also of MERCY, clemency and compassion."*

Now that we have considered God's LOVE and MERCY, *two initial steps* which God has taken in the process of rescuing and restoring depraved men back into fellowship with Himself, let us look at what Paul calls God's PURPOSE (προθεσις). This Greek noun refers to that which God has *set forth, predetermined* and *previously designed.* It progressively involves *what God had to do* in order to reclaim sinners back into fellowship with Himself.

Romans 8:28 says, "And we know that to those loving God all things work together unto good, to those being called according to His purpose." This verse indicates that God works all things unto the end of good *for a very special group* -- those being called "according to" (κατα) and in conformity with His purpose, that which He had predetermined.

As we reflect on what God has to say in His Word about His sovereignty in soteriology, we observe an *orderly progression* in that which He has decreed. These decrees set forth the *steps involved in changing men* from being sinners to being justified, hence, prepared to be glorified together with Christ.

As we juxtapose what Paul says in Romans 8:28-30 and what he says in Ephesians 2:4, the following statements should closely correspond to the *successive order* in which God decreed to lift men out of sin unto glorification with Christ (cf. Phil. 3:20-21; Col. 1:27).

First, prior to the creation of the world, before man sinned, God's PURPOSE was to restore him. This is first revealed in Genesis 3:15. Second, the fulfillment of God's sovereign purpose is solidly based upon His LOVE, which is expressed as rich MERCY unto sinners (Eph. 2:4).

Third, as a result of His love and mercy God FOREKNEW certain sinners, i.e., knew them as His own. Fourth, those individuals whom God foreknew, He also PREDESTINED to be conformed to the image of Christ. Fifth, those particular ones God predestined He also CALLED. Sixth, the ones God called He also JUSTIFIED. Seventh, when the final goal is reached, those who have been justified will be GLORIFIED (cf. Phil. 3:14, 21).

Now let us examine these seven steps, which describe how God *reaches down to sinful men* and elevates them to a glorified position with Christ. We emphasize, *God is the one who carries upward*, step by step, those whom He has chosen in Christ (Eph. 1:4). It is our purpose to cite Biblical evidence which portrays *God Himself as the subject and actor*.

GOD'S SOVEREIGN PURPOSE

In dealing with each of these steps we will describe as accurately as possible, from the Greek text, the meaning of each step. On the one hand, as far as possible, we want *to conform our translation* to the most accurate literal translations used by fundamental Bible scholars. On the other hand, as far as possible, we desire to convey into English, as precisely as we can, *just what the Greek text says*.

The Greek noun translated "purpose" (προθεσις) is derived from the compound verb "προτιθημι". "It literally means, as we have already said, that God has *set forth, predetermined* and *previously designed* HOW He will reinstate sinners into fellowship with Himself. His purpose has *seven consecutive stages* which progressively deliver the elect from sin to glory.

According to Romans 8:29, God's purpose predetermines the ones who are being "called" (εκαλεσεν). Since only those who are predestined are being called, and since God Himself is the one who executes this call, it is obvious that Paul is talking about an *efficacious call* in this verse. God's purpose determines *who is to be called*, and it assures us that the *call will be effectual.*

According to Romans 9:11-12, the Apostle Paul affirms that the purpose of God *operates according to election*. Its modus operandi is "from the one calling" (εκ τουκαλουντος); *it has its source in God*. These verses securely lock out everything a sinner might will or do as useless before God. God's purpose is to save some or certain ones "according to" (κατα) and *conforming* to " election" (εκλογην), i.e., according as He chose us in Christ before the creation of the Word (Eph. 1:4).

In Ephesians 1:11, Paul says regarding Jewish believers that they have been predestined according to the purpose of God, who works all things according to the counsel of His will. Again we observe that God *formulated His purpose first,* subsequent to which *He predestined certain ones* to be heirs in Christ. This verse, from beginning to end, *emphasizes Cod's sovereignty* in making these believers heirs in and with Christ (cf. Eph. 3:11).

In Second Timothy 1:9, Paul affirms that God "has saved and called us with a holy calling, not according to our works, but according to His own purpose and grace, that was given to us in Christ Jesus before times eternal," This verse asserts that God has called and saved us, *totally apart from our will or works,* but (αλλα) solely according to His own distinctive purpose and grace. With respect to God's purpose, Paul says that it was given to us believers prior to eternal times. This reinforces the fact that God's sovereign purpose was framed before the creation of the world (cf. Eph. 1:4).

Beginning with *God's purpose* to restore men back into fellowship with Himself, we listed seven steps. The second step is most clearly presented in Ephesians 2:4, and it deals with the LOVE and MERCY which motivated God to reinstate rebellious sinners back into a living relationship with Himself. Since this is a *subjective step*, which pertains to the counsel of God the Father, Son and Holy Spirit, we dealt with it in conjunction with Ephesians 2:1-3, the depraved plight of men.

The following five steps are presented in Romans 8:2830. They are *objective*, i.e., they explain *what God has done and is doing* on behalf of those whom He has chosen. In other words, the first two steps primarily deal with God Himself, whereas the last five steps describe *what He had to do* in order to reinstate sinners.

GOD SOVEREIGNLY FOREKNEW

The Greek verb translated "foreknew" (προεγνω) is a compound word and literally means *to know beforehand*, hence, *to know as His own* and *select in advance.* This means that God previously knew and was acquainted and familiar with the individuals whom He predestined. When we recognize that God is omniscient and unaffected by time, we readily comprehend that God knew us and our forefathers prior to conception (cf. Rom. 9:10-11). Any attempt to interpret "foreknew" to mean that God knew beforehand what we would do is to reveal one's ignorance of the context.

Paul uses the same Greek verb translated "foreknew" (προεγνω) in Romans 11:2. He affirms that "God has not cast away His people whom He foreknew." According to this statement Paul looked at Abraham and his descendants, via Isaac, *as a special people whom God foreknew* (cf. 11:25-28).

These believers knew that they were chosen and efect ones, which was verified by their lifestyle.

In writing to the elect Jews who were dispersed in Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia and Bithynia, Peter says that their relationship to God is in accordance with the "foreknowledge" (προγνωσιν) of God (1 Peter 1:2). Peter like Paul, affirms that the mercy of God plays a significant role in the sovereignty of God (1 Peter 1:3; 2:9-10).

Since the Greek verb translated "choose" (εκλεγω) is often used in a similar manner to the Greek verb rendered "foreknow" (προγινωσκω), we will consider it under this heading. This is also a compound word and literally means to speak out or to *pick out,* hence*, to choose* or *select*. The meanings of both of these words fall into the same category, *step three*, which involves God's sovereign foreknowing and choosing.

According to Ephesians 1:4, God "chose" (εξελεξατο) us, before the creation of the world, to a holy and blameless position in Christ. This clearly teaches that in the sight of God, *in Christ, we are holy and blameless* (cf. Titus 1:1-2).

According to Colossians 3:12, Paul calls them "chosen ones" (εκλεκτοι) or *elect ones of God*, and holy andbeloved ones. According to verse 13, as chosen ones, the Lord has forgiven them, and as a consequence, they are to forgive others. A right sovereign relationship with God precedes right living before God.

In First Thessalonians 1:4, Paul says, "knowing, brethren beloved by God, your election." The Greek noun translated "election" (εκλογην) may also be rendered *your choosing* or the fact that you have been chosen. These believers knew that they were chosen and elect ones, which was verified by their lifestyle. Observe the relationship between God's love and sovereign choosing -- love prompted their election.

According to Second Timothy 2:10, the Apostle Paul endured all things on account of those "chosen" (εκλεκτους) or the elect, that they might obtain the salvation which is in Christ Jesus (cf. 2 Thess. 2:13). Even though Paul was bound and confined in prison as an evildoer, still he cried out, "But the Word of God has not been bound." Regardless of his imprisonment, he was undaunted, for *his confidence was in the unbound Word of God.* He says that necessity rested upon him to preach the Word, that the "chosen" (εκλεκτους) and elect might be saved through it (1 Cor. 9:16-17).

In First Peter 1:1, the dispersed Jewish believers are referred to as "chosen" (εκλεκτοις) or elect ones (cf. Rom. 16:13). According to verse 2, *they were chosen in accordance with the foreknowledge of God.* We cite this verse again to emphasize the close tie between God's foreknowing and choosing -- to choose ensues to foreknow.

GOD SOVEREIGNLY PREDESTINED

The Greek verb translated "predestine" (προοπιζω) is a double compound word. It is derived from the preposition "προ" prefixed to the verb "οριζω." It means to *bound, limit, restrict beforehand,* and *to determine ahead of time*. In the aorist tense it is commonly translated foreordained, predestinated, predetermined and fore-appointed.

Romans 8:28, speaking of God, says, "For whom He foreknew, he also predestined as conformed ones to the image of His Son, that He might be the firstborn among many brethren."

Those whom God previously knew and with whom He was previously acquainted, He "predestined" (προωρισεν); i.e., *He marked prior boundaries around them* and *destined them as His own*. There is no way to circumvent the meaning of the Greek language used here and to simultaneously maintain one's scholarship! It means that in prior time God *marked off, determined* and *designated* certain individuals as conformed to the image of His Son.

The reason God has predestined certain ones, as stated in this clause, is to "conform" (συμμορφους) them, i.e., *make them in the same form and likeness of His Son.* Our physical body is predestined to conform to Jesus Christ's glorified body, to be glorified with Him (Phil. 3:21; cf. Rom. 8:30).

According to Ephesians 1:5, which begins with the last phrase in verse 4, Paul says that God, "in love predestined us unto a son-position through Jesus Christ unto Himself." First, *love motivated God to sovereignly predestine us* unto the "position of a son" (υιοθεσιαν) or sonship. Second, God was able to transfer us out of death unto sonship, fellowship with Himself, through the death of HIS SON (cf. Rom. 3:24-26; Gal. 3:26).

Speaking particularly to Jewish believers in Ephesians 1:11, Paul says that according to God's purpose "they had been predestined" (προοπισθεντες) to be made heirs of God's calling in conjunction with the Church (vv. 18, 22-23). The context makes it clear -- *God is the one who effects each of the steps* involved in this verse. There is no room for human willing, running or doing (Rom. 9:16).

GOD SOVEREIGNLY CALLED

THE GREEK verb translated "called" (εκαλεσεν) is used in many contexts with meanings which vary. Instead of citing the various meanings which are not pertinent to its sovereign use in the Scriptures, we will limit our citations to verses in which its use conforms to our subject.

In Romans 8:30, the Apostle Paul says, "and whom He predestined, these He also called" (εκαλεσεν). It is undeniable, *God is the sole actor, the One who has produced* the five things mentioned in verses 29-30. Verse 30 refers to a sovereign call, which God determined before the creation of the world, which is actually enacted in the process of human history.

According to Romans 9:23-24, God "made known the riches of His glory upon vessels of mercy, which He prepared beforehand unto glory, even us, whom He called, not only out of the Jews but also out of the Gentiles."

There are some who endeavor to relegate Romans, chapters 9-11, to a Jewish instead of a Church setting. We strongly disagree with this, apparently an attempt to mitigate the sovereignty of God in soteriology. These verses make it clear, *God has sovereignly, via His mercy, pre-prepared some unto glory,* whom "*He called*" (εκαλεσεν) out of both Jews and Gentiles (cf. Rom. 10:12; 1 Cor. 1:24).

First Corinthians 1:9 says that "God is faithful through whom you were called into the fellowship of His Son, Jesus Christ our Lord." We must thoroughly understand, *God is*

faithful, His call is effectual, and it is effectuated in His due time on behalf of those sovereignly called.

According to Ephesians 4:4, Paul tells us, "you were called in one hope of your calling." The passive voice indicates that *one other than themselves had "called" them* (εκληθητε), namely, God. Furthermore, the calling with which they were called had one hope, the blessed hope, *glorification with Christ* (Rom. 8:30; Titus 2:13).

> *"We must thoroughly understand, God is faithful, His call is effectual, and it is effectuated in His due time on behalf of those sovereignly called."*

In Second Thessalnnians 2:13-14, Paul says, "We are obligated to give thanks to God always for you, brethren beloved by the Lord, because God chose you from the beginning unto salvation in sanctification of the Spirit and belief of the truth, unto which He also called you through our gospel, unto obtaining the glory of our Lord Jesus Christ."

We deduct the following from these two verses. First, according to the perfect participle, *God had made them* the objects of His love. Second, *God had chosen them* from the beginning to obtain salvation. Third, in due time in human history *God "called" them* (εκαλεσεν) to share glory with the Lord Jesus Christ (cf. Rom. 8:30). As objects of His love, *God chose, predestined* and *called them* unto His ultimate purpose, glorification with Christ (Phil. 3:21).

According to Second Timothy 1:9, "God has saved us and called us with a holy calling, not according to our works, but according to His own purpose and grace, that was given to us in Christ Jesus before times eternal."

In this verse Paul deals with the sovereignty of God in salvation; however, he reverses the order, for he begins with the fact that God has saved us, and traces the steps back to before the creation of the world. Following this reversed order -- God has saved us *because "He has called" us* (καλεσαντος) with a holy calling. God has called us *because of His own purpose and grace.* God's purpose and grace was given to us *because we were in Christ Jesus.* We were in Christ *because God had sovereignly identified us with Him* before times eternal. According to this verse *God Himself sovereignly saves sinners* (cf. Gal. 1:6).

As those who have been sovereignly called by God, out of sin unto righteousness, we have been *called unto eternal life in Christ* (1 Tim. 6:12); we have been *called unto the fellowship of God's Son, Christ* (1 Cor. 1:9); and we have been *called unto eternal glory in Christ Jesus* (1 Peter 5:10). Furthermore, as believers, we have been called to a

position of freedom (Gal. 5:13), to sanctification (1 Thess. 4:7), and to a holy lifestyle (1 Peter 1:15).

Finally, in Colossians 3:15, the Apostle Paul says, "And let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts, unto which also you were called in one body; and be you thankful."

The Apostle Paul addresses those to whom he is writing in this paragraph as elect and chosen ones of God. In the light of the context, we prefer to interpret the passive Greek verb translated "called" (εκαηθητε) as a *part of God's sovereign program* enacted before the creation of the world (Eph. 1:4). All of us believers have been called to our position in the one Body of Christ, in which we are to let the peace of Christ rule in our hearts.

We emphasize, God has *irresistibly called us to our position* in the Body of Christ, the necessary *basis for peace*. However, peaceful coexistence *depends upon our obedience to His Word* given to us as Body members. On the one hand, God sovereignly places us *in the sphere of peace*, but on the other hand, we *must meet the conditions for peace* -- obedience to His Word (Titus 2:11-13).

GOD SOVEREIGNLY JUSTIFIED

Sixth, those individuals whom God sovereignly called He also JUSTIFIED. The Greek verb translated "justified" (εδικαιωσεν) in Romans 8:30 is in the aorist tense and active voice. This means that at a given point in time, prior to the creation of the world (Eph. 1:4), God, the subject of verses 28-30, declared that those whom He had called were just, right, cleared and acquitted.

In Romans 3:24, The Apostle Paul says that those who were once sinners are now "being justified freely by His grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus." Those whom God had justified, when in the process of history they come into the world, one by one God justifies them by His grace through the redemptive death of Christ Jesus on the Cross.

According to Romans 3:28, doing the works of the Mosaic Law contributes nothing to a person's justification. Paul says, "For we consider that a man is justified by faith apart from the works of the law. " The faith by which God justifies His elect is an intrinsic gift which He stimulates through His Word (cf. Rom. 10:17; Eph. 2:8; Phil. 1:29; Titus 1:1). The fact that a person believes that Christ died for his sin marks him as one whom God has chosen (cf. John 15:16; 1 Cor. 1:27-28).

Romans 5:9 also emphasizes that God Himself provides justification for us out of faith. Paul says, "Therefore having been justified out of faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ." The aorist tense and passive voice indicate that at a given point of time in the past, God, one beyond themselves, justified them "out of faith" (εκ πιστεως); i.e., the source of their justification was faith (cf. Rom. 3:30; Gal. 3:24). If this faith is humanly generated, not Divinely imparted, then justification is out of what men do (cf. Rom. 9:30-32).

Having observed that faith is the source of our justification, now let us consider that it is effected by means of the Blood of Christ. Paul says in Romans 5:9, "having been justified now by his blood, we shall be saved from the wrath through him."

Combining the thoughts of this and the preceding verse, faith is the source or agent which identifies those chosen with the means of justification, namely, the blood of Christ (cf. Col. 1:20; Heb. 9:14). For God to remain righteous and just, and to also justify sinners, the substitutionary death of Jesus Christ was necessary (cf. Rom. 3:26). The vicarious death of Christ made it possible for God to justify all men; however, only the chosen who believe are actually benefited by it (cf. 2 Tim. 2:10).

GOD SOVEREIGNLY GLORIFIED

Seventh, those whom God soveтeignly justified He also glorified. The Greek verb translated "glorified" (εδοξασεν) is in the aorist tense and active voice. This means that God, the subject of this verse, when He chose and foreknew His elect, *He glorified them*. In other words, when God enacted His purpose, since He is the one who does what He has decreed, He speaks of these decrees as *already accomplished*. The sovereign snteriological decrees of God are *unconditional* (cf. Rom. 9:1112, 16-18).

According to Romans 8:30, the Greek word for "glorified" (εδοξασεν) *refers to the heavenly body* which God has prepared for His elect (cf. 2 Cor. 5:1-5; Eph.1:14; Phil. 3:20-21). This is the ultimate "prize of the high calling of God in Christ Jesus" (Phil. 3:14). It is referred to as the inheritance of God's elect (Eph.1:14, 18).

Now that we have identified the Greek word rendered "glorified" (εδλοξασεν), in Romans 8:30, with the spiritual body designed for existence in heaven, let us look at some of the *descriptions of this body* in the Pauline Epistles. First, let us examine what Paul says about it *in three of his early epistles,* First and Second Thessalnnians and First Corinthians. Second, let us compare what he says about it *in two of his later epistles,* Second Corinthians and Philippians.

In First Thessalonians, written 50-51 A.D., six times Paul directly and indirectly, refers to the coming of Jesus Christ. In Second Thessalonians, written a few months later, he alludes to the coming of Jesus Christ four times. The main burden of these two epistles is *the fact that Christ is coming.*

In the light of Paul's strong anticipation, during his early ministry, that Christ's coming was *very, very imminent and about to occur*, he seemed to feel, that in general, those to whom he was ministering would be caught up to meet the Lord before they died (cf. 1 Cor. 7:26-31). However, when believers began to die before the Lord had come, those still living began to grieve as the hopeless unsaved. Paul's answer was that even as Jesus had died and rose, likewise, God will raise and bring them with Jesus. This means that Paul, on the basis of the truth he had *at that time,* taught that a resurrection was a necessary step in the glorification of dead believers.

In Second Thessalonians 2:13-14, Paul thanks God that he had chosen them "from the beginning unto salvation in sanctification of the Spirit and belief of the truth, unto which He also called you through our gospel, unto the obtaining of the glory of our Lord Jesus Christ." These verses corroborate the fact that *God sovereignly confirmed our glorification with Christ* prior to the creation of the world (cf. 1 Thess. 2:12; Eph. 1:4).

According to First Corinthians, chapter 15, via resurrection, the earthly body gives way *to a heavenly body* (v. 40), a body which is *the image of the heavenly* (v. 49), *a spiritual body* (v. 44), *an incorruptible body* (v. 52) and *an immortal body* (v. 53).

Whereas the main emphasis in First and Second Thessalonians (50-51 A.D.) was on the fact of Christ's coming, the emphasis in First Corinthians (53 A.D.), chapter 15:35-53, is on the resurrection body itself, *its nature and characteristics.*

In Paul's later epistles, such as chapter 5 of Second Corinthians (55-56), he refers to the glorified bodies of believers with resurrection. The implication is that whenever our earthly body (σωμα) is destroyed, we have a *non-handmade body* (σωμα) *from God, eternal in heaven* (2 Cor. 5:1).

> *"God sovereignly decreed heavenly bodies for us when He foreknew and chose us in Christ before the creation of the world."*

According to verses 2 and 3, the clear implication is that *one is either in the earthly body or heavenly body*. There is no suggestion that there is a naked or intermediary state. In fact, Paul says, that if we believers have put off our earthly bodies, i.e., have died, *we will not be found naked*; i.e., we will be in our heavenly bodies (v. 3).

According to verse 4, even though Paul is groaning in his physical body, he does not want to die, but he does want to put on his heavenly body, "that this mortal may be swallowed down by the life." The contrast in this verse is between the "mortal" (θνητον), dying body and "the life" (της ζωης), living body. The putting off of the earthly-mortal-body *is immediately followed* by putting on the heavenly-eternal-life-body (cf. vv. 6, 8).

Verse 5 makes it crystal clear, *God sovereignly decreed heavenly bodies for us* when He foreknew and chose us in Christ before the creation of the world (Rom. 8:29; Eph. 1:4). The Apostle Paul says, "God is the one who has wrought us unto this very end, who gave to us the earnest of the Spirit (cf. Eph. 1:14). The Holy Spirit Himself guarantees that God will clothe us in our heavenly bodies which are perfectly designed for our eternal existence in heaven (cf. I Cor. 15:49-50).

The Epistle to the Philippians, written about 62 A.D., *refers to believers occupying their glorified bodies apart from the resurrection*. The Apostle Paul, reflecting on continuing to live in the flesh versus to depart from it (via death), says "But I am being held between the two, having the desire to depart and be with Christ, for it is very far better" (1:23). For Paul to continue living in his earthly body meant a continuing ministry to the Philippian believers. On the other hand, if he was executed, it would mean that *he would immediately depart to be with Christ in* his glorified body. There is not the

slightest intimation that there would be a state of limbo between Paul's death and being glorified with Christ in heaven.

In Philippians 3:19-20, in contrast to the many who are enemies of the Cross of Christ and who have their minds fixed on earthly things, Paul says regarding us believers, "For our place of citizenship is in heaven, from which also we eagerly wait for the Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ; who will change the body of our lowly state, to conform to the body of His glory, according to the working whereby He is able even to subject all things to Himself." The Greek verb translated "will change" (μετασχηματισει) means that He will change us *from* our earthly body form *to the* form of His body of Glory. This does not refer to a change of the physical body, but to *a change from it to a spiritual body* which conforms to Christ's body of glory.

According to the last part of verse 21, *God is the one who gives believers heavenly bodies* like that of Christ, for "He is able even to subject all things to Himself (2 Cor. 5:1, 5). Again we emphasize, *God is the one who has both sovereignly* prepared believers to receive heavenly bodies and provides the same for them (2 Cor. 5:5).

In summarizing, first, we have considered it necessary to explain the reason for the seeming difference between what Paul says in his earlier and later epistles on this subject. Since the truth of the mystery was progressively revealed to the Apostle Paul, it is feasible to think that we may have a fuller revelation in his later epistles. Whatever our conclusion may be, it definitely appears to us that the resurrection body described in First Corinthians 15:40, 44,49, 52, 53) is the same as the "building" (οικοδομην) and non-handmade eternal "house" (οικιαν) in heaven, which is described in Second Corinthians 5:1-5.

Part 3

Pertinent Miscellaneous Thoughts

God's method of identifying sinners with Jesus Christ is through FAITH (cf. Rom. 3:28, 30; 5:1; Gal. 3:14, 26). This faith is *inseparable from the one in whom it is placed*. In other words, it is not just a matter of having faith, but *faith in Jesus Christ*, the Son of God.

THE SOURCE OF FAITH

This brings us to a very crucial issue. *What is the source of this faith?* On the one hand, those who do not accept the Biblical fact that man is totally depraved before God, hold that it has its origin in man. On the other hand, those who follow the literal-intended mean ing of the Scriptures are *forced to acknowledge* that man is totally depraved, spiritually dead before God, and not able nor interested in initiating a relationship with God (cf. Rom. 3:9-18, 23; Eph. 2:1-3).

The fact that man is in a state of rebellion against God is affirmed on every hand and throughout history. The natural man, dominated by Satan, *endeavors to eliminate every vestige of God* and His Name from everything he touches. He hates God and His Christ! If Adam and Eve, *the only free moral agents* who ever lived on this earth, obeyed Satan rather than God, isn't it utterly absurd to think that their sinful progeny would do otherwise, let alone be interested in reaching out toward God (cf. John 3:19-20).

In view of the corrupt, depraved and immoral condition of *natural men in the flesh,* who are spiritually dead, God has manifested His love in mercy toward those whom He is calling according to His purpose. *God imparts faith in conjunction with His grace.* The Greek verb "χαριζομαι," as used in the following verse, implies that God's grace is not limited to the Cross, *but includes the means* by which its benefits are extended to sinners (Rom. 8:32; 2 Cor. 2:12; Phil. 1:29).

The key verse in the New Testament, which teaches that grace, faith and consequent salvation constitute a gift from God, is Ephesians 2:8. The following is a literal translation of it: "For by grace you have been saved through faith, and this is not out of you, it is the gift of God." Those who refuse to acknowledge that man is totally depraved, and spiritually dead, and who hold that it is dead sinners who choose God, rather than God who chooses men according to His, will must recognize that this verse contradicts their position.

Since they desire that this verse say less than what it obviously says, they have found a supposed grammatical gem in the Greek language, *which they think* excludes faith from being a gift of God. Since the Greek noun translated "faith" (πιστεως) is in the

feminine gender, and the demonstrative pronoun "this" (τουτο) in the neuter gender, *they contend that the latter does not refer to the word faith*; i.e., faith is not a gift of God but something which is innate in spiritually dead sinners, enabling them to choose a relationship with the Living God.

After having *carefully considered* the Greek grammar used in Ephesians 2:8, we are convinced that the first clause in this verse, "for by grace you have been saved through faith," *is an inseparable and indivisible thought*. The Greek nouns translated "grace" (χαριτι) and "faith" (πιστεως) are both in the feminine gender and *integral parts of a single clause*. Therefore, if faith is not from God, neither is grace. Since we cannot deny that God gives grace, neither can we deny that He gives faith (cf. Rom.1:7; 1 Cor. 15:10).

In Philippians 1:28, we have the *same grammatical principle*, with the same neuter pronoun referring to a feminine noun. Paul says, "and do not be frightened in anything by the adversaries, which is evidence of destruction to them, but of your salvation, and this from God." The Greek noun for "salvation" (σωτηριας) is in the feminine gender while the Greek pronoun for "this" (τουτο) is in the neuter gender.

In Romans 4:15-16, we have a *similar relationship* between the feminine and neuter genders. Paul says, "for the law works wrath; and where there is no law, neither is there transgression. Because of this it is out of faith, that it maybe according to grace." Observe, the Greek noun translated "wrath" (οργην) and the Greek noun rendered "transgression" (παραβασις) are in the feminine gender. The Greek pronoun translated "this" (τουτο) is in the neuter gender. With reference to the presence and absence of the law, the results are either wrath or no transgression. In referring back to *this single clause,* the meaning of which hinges on two feminine nouns, Paul uses the neuter pronoun "this" (τουτο).

Likewise, in First Corinthians 11:23-24, we have the *neuter pronoun* "this" (τουτο) used to refer to a *masculine noun*. Paul says, "for I received from the Lord, that the Lord Jesus in the night in which He was betrayed took bread; and when He had given thanks, he broke it, and said, `This is my body on behalf of you."' Here Paul uses the neuter pronoun "this" (τουτο) with reference to the masculine noun for "bread" (αρτον).

Furthermore, in Romans 13:5-6, we again have a neuter pronoun used to refer to two feminine nouns *in a single clause*. Speaking of authorities, Paul says, "it is necessary to be arranged under, not only because of wrath but also because of conscience. For on account of this also pay taxes." The neuter Greek pronoun "this" (τουτο), in these verses, refers to the feminine nouns "wrath" (οργην) and "conscience" (συνειδησιν), *integral parts of a cohesive clause.*

In Second Thessalonians 2:13-14, a feminine noun is *the antecedent of a relative neuter pronoun.* Paul says that "God chose you from the beginning unto salvation in sanctification of the Spirit and belief of the truth, unto which also He called you." Note, the Greek neuter pronoun "which" (ο) is used with reference to the. Greek feminine noun for "salvation" (σωτηριαν; 1 Peter 1:5-6). (cf. Heb. 1:9; δια τουτο)

In view of Ephesians 2:8, *and the corroborative evidence* we have cited in the preceding verses, the demonstrative neuter pronoun "τουτο" (this) *refers to a noun of a different gender which is an integral part of the foregoing clause.* This neuter pronoun refers to what was confirmed in the preceding clause, adding further details.

The following verses imply that *God is the one who gives faith* (1 Cor. 12:9; Gal. 2:20; 5:22; Eph. 6:11-16). Romans 10:17 says that "faith is out of hearing, and the hearing is through the word of Christ." This indicates that the source of faith is *comprehending and understanding* the word of Christ/God. On the basis of this verse, we recognize that *this is one way* God stimulates faith in His elect, but we *must not prematurely conclude that it is the only way,* for this would be to irrationally limit God (cf. Rom. 11:34).

FAITH

Lest some may look at the word "faith" (πιστις) as having intrinsic, magical power in itself, let us look at its *basic meaning* and examples of how it is used in the New Testament.

Where a given thought is expressed by both a verb and a noun, as in the case before us, we go back to the verb form for its basic meaning. The Greek verb "πιστευω" means *to be mentally persuaded, to believe that something or someone is true,* hence *to trust, believe* and *have confidence in one or in what he has said.*

When Romans 4:3 says that "Abraham believed God and it was counted to Him for righteousness," it means that he was counted righteous because *he trusted and had confidence in God and in what He had said.* Also, in Acts 16:31, when Paul says, "Believe on the Lord Jesus and you will be saved," he means that the person who *confidently trusts and depends on all that He is and has done will be saved* (cf. Rom. 3:25; Gal. 2:16).

> *"The Spirit preveniently opens the eyes of those called to see God the Father and the Son and His substitutionary death on the cross, and mentally persuades them to trust, believe and have confidence in Him."*

The unsaved natural man in the flesh *is not able to know the things of the Spirit,* for they are foolishness to him (1 Cor. 1:18; 2:14; Rom. 8:7-8). This means that if God had not taken the initiative, and called, chosen, and Himself put us in Christ, we would all still be unsaved, natural sinners (1 Cor.1:24,27-28,30). Paul says that the Spirit of God enables us, those chosen, to know what has been "graced" (χαρισθεντα) unto us by God. *The Spirit preveniently opens the eyes of those called to see God the Father and the Son and His substitutionary death on the Cross and mentally persuades them to trust,*

believe and have confidence in Him (2 Cor. 2:12). It is utterly impossible to understand how anyone can fulfill the meaning of "faith" (πιστις), unless God imparts to him, via His Spirit, sufficient knowledge regarding the One in whom he is to trust or have faith. In other words, this Greek word translated "faith" (πιστις) implies that *God gives faith and trust in a specific Person* worthy of it, Jesus Christ (cf. Acts 4:12).

AS A BIBLICIST

Some people seem to find personal satisfaction in calling believers by various names, such as Calvanist, Arminian, HyperCalvanist, Hyperdispensationalist, Bullingerite, etc. The tone or context in which these names are used generally implies that those using them are not interested in maintaining the unity of the Spirit (Eph. 4:3). These names are commonly resorted to by those *who think they have the truth*, but they are unable to support and defend their position *by the Word of God written to and for the Church, the Body of Christ* (cf. 1 Cor. 2:6-10; 2 Cor. 5:16-21; Gal. 1:6-12; Eph. 3:2-9; Col. 1:24-29; 1 Thess. 2:13; 1 Tim. 6:3-5; 2 Tim. 1:8-14; 2:15-16; et al.).

As BIBLICISTS, we are wedded to our Greek New Testaments, leaving no stone unturned as we seek to derive its *literal intended meaning*. This means that we will cut across the grain of many whose thinking is circumscribed by the multitude of traditional views abroad. If the Lord's people were good Bereans, and would search the Word of God written to and for the Church, *they themselves would be able to determine* whether a Biblicist is saying what the Word says. Sad to say, however, there are few who go to God's Word; most go to their denominational leaders, who only too frequently, driven by many motives, tend to directly or indirectly defame the Biblicist, and *thereby defame the irrefutable truth which he teaches* from the Word of God for the Church (cf. Col. 1:25-26).

As a Biblicist, *we must avoid being prejudiced and biased*, pro or con, regarding what God says in His Word. In other words, *we must guard against* being predisposed toward certain truths while having an antipathy against others. For example, on the one hand, we may accurately follow the literal meaning of the Pauline Epistles with respect to distinguishing the things which differ (Phi1.1:10), and on the other hand, disregard what they say about God's sovereignty in the salvation of sinners (Rom. 9:11).

To the extent that we approach the Scriptures with a biased mind, *we disqualify ourselves as objective exegetes*, interpreters and Bible teachers. The prime example of this is A. T. Robertson's abortive effort to make the Greek preposition "εις," in Acts 2:38, not contradict his denominational views[1]. If one withholds what the Bible teaches for the sake of his job, support, social status, etc., he is not worthy of the name Biblicist.

If being biased and predisposed toward certain views, or having preconceived preferences, cause us to blot out or to cringe from teaching what God says in His Word, *then we need to consider the source of these biases in order to eradicate them*. In dealing with the source from which these biases are derived, we will limit our discussion to the more obvious ones.

First, the person raised and trained in a given denomination will tend to be limited in what he sees and teaches to his denominational perspective. The only thing which will enable him to eradicate his biases, right or wrong, is *to personally study the New Testament for its literal-intended meaning*. The person who does this will recognize that

the Synoptic Gospels of Matthew, Mark and Luke are written to the Jews, *not the Church*, regarding their prophesied Messianic Kingdom.

Second, the person who bathes his mind in *humanistic writings* will tend to have his biased mind veiled against seeing the sovereignty of God in soteriology. The only way to be extricated from this spiritual malady is to lay aside what has caused it and *concentrate on the literal-intended meaning of the New Testament Epistles written to and for the Church, the Body of Christ.* Commentaries which are written to bring out the meaning of the original language will be most helpful in this area.

Third, in summary, anything that anyone might say, teach and do, which is contrary to the Gospel of the Grace of God, and has a potential to prejudice one against the literal-intended meaning of the Gospel of Grace, in its salvation aspect, *should be cleansed from the mind by the Word of God* (cf. John 15:3).

God's sovereignty in salvation is the *antitheses* of salvation by human works. These are mutually exclusive (Rom. 11:6).

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[1] "After all is done, instances remain where syntax cannot say the last word, where theological bias will enevitably determine how one interprets the Greek idiom. . . . When the grammarian has finished, the theologian steps in, and sometimes before the grammarian is through."

"A Grammar of The Greek New Testament In The Light of Historical Research," by A. T. Robertson, Broadman, 1934, pg. 389.